



THY GRAVE ERROR AND TRANSGRESSION

THE TRIAL OF GALILEO GALILEI (1633)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

The crime of heresy

BEFORE

1542 The Roman Inquisition is established by the Catholic Church to counter heresy.

1543 Nicolaus Copernicus's book *De Revolutionibus Orbium Coelestium* (*On the Revolutions of the Heavenly Spheres*) is published.

1600 The Roman Inquisition sentences to death Italian cosmologist Giordano Bruno for heresy, in part because he says stars are distant suns.

AFTER

1757 The Catholic Church lifts the ban on Galileo's *Dialogue on the Two Chief World Systems*.

1989 The Iranian Islamic government denounces author Salman Rushdie as a heretic.

1992 The Vatican accepts that Galileo was correct in adopting the Copernican theory.

Polish astronomer Nicolaus Copernicus published his book *On the Revolutions of the Heavenly Spheres* in 1543. He put forward the theory that Earth orbits the Sun (which became known as heliocentrism), contrary to the then-accepted view that the Sun rotates around a stationary Earth (geocentrism).

Heliocentrism challenged both the natural philosophy of Aristotle and the traditional ideas of the Catholic Church. Copernicus's theory was widely dismissed as far-fetched, but in 1616, respected Italian astronomer Galileo Galilei revived it. As a result, the Church banned him from teaching or defending heliocentric ideas. Galileo was warned not to espouse anything other than the accepted Church view that Earth was the center of the universe.

Heliocentric theory

Galileo continued his studies and in 1632 published *Dialogue on the Two Chief World Systems*, which once again discussed the heliocentric

theory. The Church brought Galileo before the Roman Inquisition in 1633. Galileo admitted no wrongdoing but accepted a plea bargain in which he agreed not to promote heliocentrism. He was found guilty of heresy, put under house arrest, and had his book banned. It was not until 1822 that the Catholic College of Cardinals accepted that the heliocentric theory could be true. In 1992, Galileo was finally cleared of heresy. ■



The proposition that the sun is immovable in the center of the world ... is absurd, philosophically false, and formally heretical ...

Indictment against Galileo Galilei, 1633



See also: Aristotle and natural law 32–33 ■ The origins of canon law 42–47
■ Gratian's *Decretum* 60–63 ■ The Salem witch trials 104–105